sports club and, after some discussion, decided she would put my name down for the Under-10 event. I was only six and still a few months from starting primary school, but she believed I could hold my own.

It would be my first experience of proper, organised competition in any sport and I could hardly have been more excited to see my name in the first of two groups of eight. We were going to play a round-robin format, with everyone playing against everyone else in each group. Every match would comprise nine games and the winner would be the player who finished with the highest aggregate number of games won.

I was drawn to play against the No. 1 seed in my opening match of the day and, perhaps understandably, the talented nine-year-old appeared slightly annoyed at being asked to play against the small, pesky six-year-old who was bouncing around and just couldn't wait to get started on the opposite side of the net.

There were some decent rallies and most of the games went to deuce, but I trailed 0–1, 0–2, 0–3 and then 0–4. I was not happy. When we passed at the net, changing ends between the fifth and sixth games, I deliberately bumped into him, even if I was not quite tall enough for my shoulder to connect with his shoulder.

He ignored my antics and eased to an 8–1 win. At the end, I refused to shake hands, burst into tears, stormed off court, climbed a tree and scrambled onto the roof of the clubhouse.

'AB, please come down,' my mother pleaded.

'No,' I said, sobbing.

'Come on, AB, please behave and come down.'

'No.'

The tantrum lasted for around 10 minutes until my increasingly embarrassed mother persuaded me to climb down from the roof by promising to buy me a remote-control electric car.

Tears dried, I pulled myself together and managed to win my second